

I. GENDER BIAS IN TECH

A. READING

1. VOCABULARY

Look up the words underlined in the text. Find a synonym or a definition.

2. QUESTIONS ON THE TEXT

1. What is it like being a woman in Tech? Facing sexism, bias, exclusion, and a high dropout rate.
2. What are the things Blount did that helped her succeed in her career?
Ignoring sexist remarks, avoiding gender discussions, staying focused on work.
3. What are the things women like about working in tech?
Problem-solving, teamwork, fast career growth, high salaries, innovation.
4. What is this gender gap due to?
Unconscious bias, "genius" culture, unequal funding, interruptions in meetings, persistent sexism
5. *"We as individuals become smarter, better versions of ourselves when we are working on teams that are diverse."*
Do you agree?
What might be the impact of the underrepresentation of women in tech?
Less innovation, biased products, talent loss, lack of role models for young girls
6. Do you have an idea of apps that might help solve this problem?
Mentorship apps (e.g., ADPList), sexism reporting platforms, diversity training programs

B. WATCHING

How Did Tech Become So Male-Dominated?

The Atlantic

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OZ7zX6LalLI>

1. What was the role of women during World War II?
During World War II, women were hired by the military to solve complex calculations that would improve the accuracy of weapons on the battlefield.
2. What did women work on in the 50s and 60s? What about men?
In the 50s and 60s, women often worked behind the scenes, building software, while men specialized in hardware engineering.
3. How was programming considered?
Programming was considered mindless and menial work during this time, which led to it becoming associated with women's work.
4. What was the percentage of women majoring in computer science in 1984? What about today?
In 1984, women majoring in computer science made up 37% of the field. Today, the percentage is around 18%.
5. What changed in the 1980s?
The shift from hardware engineering to software development, with male figures like Steve Jobs and Bill Gates becoming industry heroes.
6. What is the reason for not hiring women?
Women were considered not a "culture fit," meaning male employees struggled to socialize with them.

Why Is Silicon Valley So Awful to Women?

Tech companies are spending hundreds of millions of dollars to improve conditions for female employees. Here's why not much has changed—and what might actually work.

By [Liza Mundy](#)

One weekday morning in 2007, Bethanye Blount came into work early to interview a job applicant. A veteran software engineer then in her 30s, Blount held a senior position at the company that runs Second Life, the online virtual world. Good-natured and self-confident, she typically wore the kind of outfit—jeans, hoodie, sneakers—that signals coding gravitas. That day, she might even have been wearing what's known as the “full-in start-up twin set”: a Second Life T-shirt paired with a Second Life hoodie.

In short, everything about her indicated that she was a serious technical person. So she was taken aback when the job applicant barely gave her the time of day. He knew her job title. He knew she would play a key role in deciding whether he got hired. Yet every time Blount asked him a question about his skills or tried to steer the conversation to the scope of the job, he blew her off with a flippant comment. Afterward, Blount spoke to another top woman—a vice president—who said he'd treated her the same way.

Obviously Second Life wasn't going to hire this bozo. But what the heck: he was here, and they had a new employee, a man, who needed practice giving interviews, so they sent him in. When the employee emerged, he had an odd look on his face. “I don't know what just happened,” he said. “I went in there and told him I was new, and all he said was he was so glad I was there: ‘Finally, somebody who knows what's going on!’ ”

All Blount could do was laugh—even now, as she looks back on the incident. In the hierarchy of sexist encounters, it didn't rank very high. Still, it was a reminder that as a woman in tech, she should be prepared to have her authority questioned at any moment, even by some guy trying to get a job at her company.

One reason her career had gone so well, she thinks, is that she'd made a point of ignoring slights and oafish comments. Awkward silences, too. Over the years, she's experienced—many times—the sensation of walking up to a group of male colleagues and noticing that they fell quiet, as though they'd been talking about something they didn't want her to hear. She's been asked to take notes in meetings. She's found herself standing in elevators at tech conferences late at night when a guy would decide to get, as she puts it, handsy. When she and a male partner started a company, potential investors almost always directed their questions to him—even when the subject clearly fell in Blount's area of expertise. It drove him crazy, and Blount had to urge him to curb his irritation. “I didn't have time to be pissed,” she says.

But at some point, something inside her broke. Maybe it was being at tech conferences and hearing herself, the “elder stateswoman,” warning younger women to cover their drinks, because such conferences—known for alcohol, after-parties, and hot women at product booths—have been breeding grounds for unwanted sexual advances and assaults, and you never knew whether some jerk might put something in your cocktail. She couldn't believe that women still had to worry about such things; that they still got asked to fetch coffee; that she still heard talk about how hiring women or people of color entailed “lowering the bar”; that women still, often, felt silenced or attacked when expressing opinions online.

“I am angry that things are no better for a 22-year-old at the beginning of her career than they were for me 25 years ago when I was just starting out,” Blount says. “I made decisions along the way that were easier for me and helped me succeed—don't bring attention to being a woman, never talk about gender,

never talk about ‘these things’ with men,” unless the behavior was particularly egregious. “It helped me get through. But in retrospect I feel I should have done more.”

Blount decided it was never too late to start speaking out, and teamed up with other women who had undergone a similar awakening. This past May, they formed a group called Project Include, which aims to provide companies and investors with a template for how to be better. (...)

The dozens of women I interviewed for this article love working in tech. They love the problem-solving, the camaraderie, the opportunity for swift advancement and high salaries, the fun of working with the technology itself. They appreciate their many male colleagues who are considerate and supportive. Yet all of them had stories about incidents that, no matter how quick or glancing, chipped away at their sense of belonging and expertise. (...)

Such undermining is one reason women today hold only about a quarter of U.S. computing and mathematical jobs—a fraction that has actually fallen slightly over the past 15 years, even as women have made big strides in other fields. Women not only are hired in lower numbers than men are; they also leave tech at more than twice the rate men do. It’s not hard to see why. Studies show that women who work in tech are interrupted in meetings more often than men. They are evaluated on their personality in a way that men are not. They are less likely to get funding from venture capitalists, who, studies also show, find pitches delivered by men—especially handsome men—more persuasive. And in a particularly cruel irony, women’s contributions to open-source software are accepted more often than men’s are, but only if their gender is unknown. (...)

That the tech industry would prove so hostile to women is more than a little counterintuitive. Silicon Valley is populated with progressive, hyper-educated people who talk a lot about making the world better. It’s also a young field, with none of the history of, say, law or medicine, where women were long denied spots in graduate schools intended for “breadwinning men.”

“We don’t have the same histories of exclusion,” says Joelle Emerson, the founder and CEO of Paradigm, a firm in San Francisco that advises companies on diversity and inclusion. But being new comes with its own problems: Because Silicon Valley is a place where a newcomer can unseat the most established player, many people there believe—despite evidence everywhere to the contrary—that tech is a meritocracy. Ironically enough, this very belief can perpetuate inequality. A 2010 study, “The Paradox of Meritocracy in Organizations,” found that in cultures that espouse meritocracy, managers may in fact “show greater bias in favor of men over equally performing women.” In a series of three experiments, the researchers presented participants with profiles of similarly performing individuals of both genders, and asked them to award bonuses. The researchers found that telling participants that their company valued merit-based decisions only increased the likelihood of their giving higher bonuses to the men.

Such bias may be particularly rife in Silicon Valley because of another of its foundational beliefs: that success in tech depends almost entirely on innate genius. Nobody thinks that of lawyers or accountants or even brain surgeons; while some people clearly have more aptitude than others, it’s accepted that law school is where you learn law and that preparing for and passing the CPA exam is how you become a certified accountant. Surgeons are trained, not born. In contrast, a 2015 study published in *Science* confirmed that computer science and certain other fields, including physics, math, and philosophy, fetishize “brilliance,” cultivating the idea that potential is inborn. The report concluded that these fields tend to be problematic for women, owing to a stubborn assumption that genius is a male trait.

<https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/archive/2017/04/why-is-silicon-valley-so-awful-to-women/517788/>

II. BIAS IN AI

Ted Talk : “How to keep human bias out of AI” by Kriti Sharma

https://www.ted.com/talks/kriti_sharma_how_to_keep_human_bias_out_of_ai

Questions:

1. What are common concerns about AI?

2. Give at least three examples of assumptions AI make.

- Identity
- race
- age
- gender

3. What do Siri, Alexa and Cortana have in common?

- All female
- obedient servants

4. What are male AIs like?

More powerful, more serious applications

5. What does that teach children growing in this environment?

Woman were considered as assistant

6. What are three things we can do to teach AIs the right values and the right ethics?

- Be aware of our own bias
-
-

7. What did Kriti Sharma have to do on tech forums not to have her qualifications or abilities questioned?

TO be not gendered

8. What kind of people do we need to make great AI?

- Issues
-
-
-

Discussion:

"This kind of gender discrimination is not OK. And yet somehow, AI has become above the law, because a machine made the decision." (3:45)

AI algorithms are helping make critical decisions in areas such as crime and policing, credit and lending, recruitment and health care. This is often powered by a technique called deep learning, which makes it difficult to build "explainability" into the algorithms, thereby reducing trust. This lack of transparency into explaining how algorithmic decisions are made is raising questions and calls for regulation of AI technology.

On "explainability", see: <https://www.economist.com/science-and-technology/2018/02/17/for-artificial-intelligence-to-thrive-it-must-explain-itself>

How should we move forward?

QUESTION 1 :- Held a senior position Had a high-ranking role - Ta